SOMUN’26 (Silver Oaks Model united nations)

INTERNATIONAL PRESS BACKGROUND GUIDE



LETTER FROM THE EXECUTIVE BOARD

Greetings,

We are delighted to welcome you to the International Press, where words are not just tools, but instruments of analysation. The International Press is not simply about putting proceedings into words or capturing them through a camera lens. It is about observing closely, asking the questions that matter, and what can be established as fact and what you could interpret and put forward as an opinion that is yours . Throughout the conference, you will document the discussions taking place in your respective committees and, in doing so, decide how those discussions are presented to the world by your articles and photography. True journalism requires more than good writing. It demands curiosity, patience, and the willingness to verify before reporting. As members of the International Press, you are the connection between the committee room and those who are not in it rather viewing it through your writing and proceedings . With that comes the responsibility to ensure that your work remains factual, transparent, and fair. Remember, true journalism also lies in your interpretation of what you might think is going and what is. The spirit of International Press lies in collective excellence. While individual recognition is rewarding, our purpose extends beyond competition: it lies in collaboration. Each article drafted and each photograph taken contributes to the larger story we tell the people beyond this conference. This guide will help you understand your responsibilities, elevate your reporting skills, and understand how the International Press works. We look forward to working with you and providing you with a good learning experience.

Ananya Harikrishnan	Tejo Risheek	Chinmayi Bachina
Editor-In-Chief	Head of International Press	Head of Photography

ABOUT INTERNATIONAL PRESS

The International Press (IP) is neither a traditional committee of the United Nations nor an official part of any UN committee. Within a Model United Nations (MUN), the IP refers to the collection of international press agencies or independent journalists from all corners of the world to report on the activities of the proceedings of various committees.

Regardless, the International Press plays a key role in the conference. Through objective reporting, critical analysis and visual storytelling, the IP keeps readers informed on key developments, provides insights into the committee and offers a broader perspective on the proceedings.

By holding delegates accountable for their actions and statements, the IP encourages transparency and serves as a bridge between the debate in the room and the wider world they shape.

The International Press provides a platform where committee proceedings are scrutinised, and the focus of the public eye is on not just the final outcomes, but also the process that got them there.

However, with this influence comes the responsibility to report accurately, ethically and objectively. The quality of a good journalist is being able to distinguish verified facts from speculation and create compelling reports without misrepresenting a delegate’s position.

Ultimately, the International Press is a space for observation, inquiry and storytelling. It ensures delegates take accountability for their statements and actions, while challenging reporters to capture the essence of debate in a way that is accessible to the world. The strength of the International Press does not lie in its ability to report what happened, but in its capacity to examine why it matters.

JOURNALISM

TYPES OF SUBMISSIONS

Journalists will be submitting a variety of articles, each reflecting its own aspect of the committee activities and proceedings. It is important to understand the essence of each article as every one has a different format, writing style and approach.

Beat Article: A beat is an observation-based article that provides an in-depth report of a specific event or discussion in committee. It is a short, informative piece written in third person, and should not contain the opinions of the journalist.
Word limit: 300-400 words

Creative Article: This submission is one that gives the journalist full creative liberty. They can experiment with themes, formats, tone and structure as they wish. A creative piece can be anything, from diary entries to stories. The only requirement is that they remain relevant to the agenda, and convey the message in a way that attracts reader attention.
Word limit: 150-900 words

Opinionated-Editorial: An opinionated editorial(Op-Ed) is an article that allows the journalist to analyze and express their opinion on the committee's agenda and discussions. An Op-Ed also allows research to shine through, as the interpretations and opinions of the journalist must be backed by factual evidence and logic. It is written in third person.
Word limit: 500-600 words

Interview Transcript: An interview transcript is a record of a conversation between the journalist and a delegate. A journalist uses the interview as an opportunity to learn more about a delegate's stance, actions, etc, that would otherwise not be discussed in committee. Questions must provide insight into the delegate's opinions while still remaining relevant to the agenda. The article format

is as follows:
International Press(IP): Question
Delegate of the United States of America(USA): Answer
IP: Follow up question
USA: Response to question

Minor grammatical errors can be fixed, but the essence of the delegate's response must be the same.
Word limit: Around 6 questions(400-650 words)

Collaborative Piece: Collaborative pieces bring the written and visual aspects of journalism together to create an account of events in a committee. Each piece is the joint effort of a journalist and a photojournalist and combines creative writing with visual reporting to provide readers a more in-depth understanding of committee proceedings.
Word limit: 400-500 words

Opinion Poll: An opinion poll allows journalists to collect, analyse and present the perspectives of delegates on a specific issue related to the agenda. The poll consists of a single, unbiased question that elicits thoughtful responses from the committee. The data is interpreted with the help of visual representations such as pie charts, graphs, etc. This provides readers with clarity on the committee's views on the issue at hand.
Word limit: 200-400 words

Consolidated Report: A submission that covers and summarises all three days of the conference. It gives the reader an overall understanding of committee dynamics, significant developments and the main outcomes of the committee. From the opening speeches and discussions in between to the eventual conclusions of the committee, a consolidated report must provide a clear, concise report of how the debate progressed and the committee evolved.
Word limit: 300-500 words

Press Conference

A press conference gives journalists the chance to directly question delegates about their stances in committee. Questions may be about a country's policies, a statement made by the delegate or an action taken during debate. It is also an opportunity to clear up points that have been left uncleared and to examine a delegate's position on the agenda more closely.

Questions must be clear, concise and backed by credible evidence or observations of the committee. A press conference is another place where the research element of the International Press is prominent, so ensure to come well prepared. Prioritise the relevance, depth and quality of questions over the sheer number of them.

Another important thing to note is decorum during the press conference. Delegates may be questioned firmly-especially when there are apparent contradictions in their statements or policies-but with the utmost professionalism, rather than provocation or intimidation.

HOW TO RESEARCH

A journalist is expected to be thorough with their research, because it forms the basis for what they write. An opinion cannot be expressed in the submissions without sufficient factual evidence. Not all sources are reliable, which is why journalists should ensure that information is verified before using it in an article. The following are a few sources that can be used for research, ranked from most to

least credible:

1) Primary Sources:
    - Official UN documentation and websites(such as www.ohchr.org, etc)
    - Government Reports (India: Ministry of External Affairs , United States: USA.gov , United Kingdom:GOV.UK, Australia: Australian Government)

How delegates should use them: Prefer these sources for official policies, laws, statistics, resolutions and statements. Remember that a government source establishes what that government says or publishes, not necessarily that every claim it makes is independently verified.

2) Secondary Sources:
    - International news agencies such as Reuters (Reuters) or BBC : (BBC News) can be used as credible sources of information. However, controversial news agencies should ideally be avoided as they may not always be accurate.
    - State owned news agencies such as All India Radio(India) and ABC(Australia) are also considered sources of information generally used either in favour of or against a country. :(Akashvani / News on AIR , ABC News)

How delegates should use them: Compare reports from more than one credible outlet, check the date, look for cited evidence and distinguish factual reporting from opinion or analysis.

3) Tertiary sources:
    - Wikipedia: Since it is an open-source platform, it is not considered to be reliable.
    - Social Media: Most posts and comments on social media are considered unreliable, but certain press releases or posts by a

government or person of interest may be used after consulting with the EB.

FORMATTING AND SUBMISSION GUIDELINES

- Submit all articles by the time mentioned in that day's briefing
- All submissions must be in the form of a word document(.docx)
- Font(except creative): Times New Roman
- Headlines: 14 pt, Bold, Centre Alignment
- Byline: 13 pt, Italicised, Justified
- Image/Photo credits: 12 pt, Italicised, Centre Alignment
- Body: 12 pt, Justified
- Naming format: Reporter Name_Article Type_Committee_Day
  Ex) Ananya Harikrishnan_Creative_UNHRC_Day2

RULES AND REGULATIONS

- Bylines are mandatory for every article. They are sentences that summarise your articles.
  Ex) "*Ananya Harikrishnan, reporting from the United Nations Commission on the Status of Women (UNCSW), on the committee's stance on the protection of women in conflict-prone zones."*
- Plagiarism and use of AI is strictly prohibited.
- Refer to a delegate by their assigned portfolio only. Avoid personal pronouns as well.
- Avoid using contractions. Use 'cannot' instead of 'can't'
- Use abbreviations only after introduction.
  Ex) The delegate of the United States of America(USA)
- Numbers up to a hundred must be written in words(such as 'seven', 'twenty-two') with the exception of dates.
- Maintain proper punctuation and grammar.
- Ensure your articles are objective and avoid personal bias while reporting.

- Maintain respectful decorum while observing the committee or interacting with delegates.

PHOTO JOURNALISM

Dear photojournalists,

It is our pleasure to welcome you to the photojournalism division of the Internal Press at SOMUN 2026. As members of this team you will be responsible for documenting the conference and capturing the moments that unfold throughout its course

Photojournalism is not limited to photographing speeches and committee sessions. It is about observing the people, interactions and moments that make the conference what it is.
It requires attentiveness to detail, creativity in framing moments, and discipline in meeting deadlines with professionalism. We encourage you to look beyond the obvious, experiment with your perspective and capture photographs that are both meaningful and engaging.

You are expected to maintain the highest standards of courtesy within committees, ensuring your presence never disrupts the flow of debate while still capturing its essence.
We hope that you approach this conference with creativity, responsibility and enthusiasm. YOur photographs will be an important part of how this MUN is remembered, and we look forward to seeing the conference through your work.

Please feel free to reach out for any enquiries and do not hesitate to ask for help or guidance

Sincerely,
Chinmayi Bachina
Head of photojournalism
chinmayibachina@gmail.com

2. Code of Conduct & Guidelines
Photojournalists are expected to:

- Maintain professionalism and courtesy: Treat delegates, chairs, staff, and fellow press members with respect at all times.

- Follow conference guidelines: Adhere to the rules and instructions provided by the Secretariat and International Press.

- Uphold originality: Only submit photographs taken personally during the conference. Reusing or submitting another photographer's work is strictly prohibited.

- Respect personal boundaries: Do not engage delegates in unscheduled conversations or interviews during committee sessions. Your role is to observe and document, not participate in proceedings.

- Be punctual and responsible: Arrive on time for assigned coverage and remain attentive to your responsibilities throughout the conference.

- Minimize distractions: While covering committees, avoid flash photography, unnecessary movement or noise, and never interrupt proceedings for a photograph.

- Collaborate with the team: Communicate with fellow photojournalists and other members of the International Press, offer assistance when needed, and contribute positively to the team.

3. Submissions

All photojournalists are required to submit their photographs daily according to the following instructions. Timely submissions are essential for evaluation, and failure to meet the deadlines may result in consequences

Each day you must submit 5 photographs in each of the following criteria

1. Individual portraits – individual candid shots of delegates/EB members
2. Story/narrative- a moment that captures a significant moment or tells a visual story of the day.
3. Committee sessions – Wide or medium shots capturing debates and interactions

This amounts to 15 coverage photographs per day.

Each day should focus on certain styles of shots and angles. To guide your approach a few suggested themes have been mentioned below. These themes are suggestions, not strict rules as your main priority is fulfilling the above criteria of submissions

DAY1:
•Eye level shots
•Candid reactions
•Abstract
DAY2:
•Closeups
•Rule of Thirds
•Monochrome
DAY3:
•Over the shoulder
•Low angle/High angle
•Frame-in-Frame

In addition to these categories a creative assignment is communicated by the head of photography each day. Photojournalists are expected to follow the daily brief while approaching each category with creativity and their own perspective.

4. Format and camera guidelines

All photographs are required to be submitted in jpg/jpeg format.
These submissions must be uploaded in Google Drive and named according to the submission criteria they fall in.
For convenient and proper organization, make a folder in Google Drive titled in the format given: [Name_SOMUN2026_photojournalism] In the folder, create 3 subfolders, one for each day and submit accordingly
[Day_1]
[Day_2]
[Day_3]
Editing of the photographs is permitted as long as the natural essence of the photo remains the same. When submitting edited photographs, make sure to attach the unedited version along with it.

Mentioned below are the cameras/devices that are preferred/recommended for use:
- DSLRs [Nikon, Canon, Panasonic, Sony, Fujifilm]
- iPhones 12-18, iPhone SE
- Samsung S20-24